RAHUL UPS THE ANTE

From the Opposition leader's "vote *chori*" allegation in Karnataka to Bihar's contested revisions, disputes over voter rolls deepen the crisis of confidence in the Election Commission's ability to safeguard electoral integrity

By KAUSHIK DEKA

ON AUGUST 7, AT THE CONGRESS HEADQUARTERS IN NEW DELHI, party leader Rahul Gandhi stood in a room filled with cameras and anticipation, holding what he described as proof of India's gravest democratic crisis. The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha raised a spiral-bound stack of papers, culled from a seven-foot pile of electoral rolls, and levelled a dramatic charge: the Election Commission of India (ECI) was overseeing "vote *chori*", an orchestrated theft within voter lists. As evidence, he pointed to the rolls of Karnataka's Mahadevapura assembly seat, under the Bangalore Central Lok Sabha constituency, alleging that over 100,000 fraudulent votes had been inserted in those rolls via systematic manipulation, skewing the 2024 Lok Sabha election result in favour of the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

The numbers Rahul presented were staggering: 11,965 entirely fake voters, 40,009 registered at non-existent addresses, 10,452 mysteriously clustered at single locations. His "exposé" quickly reverberated beyond Karnataka, hinting at a broader pattern of electoral irregularities across India. In Kerala's Thrissur, for example, a woman recently discovered that nine strangers had been added to the voter list using her home address. Thrissur, where the BJP secured its first-ever Lok Sabha victory in the state this year, had seen its voter count swell by 146,656 between 2019 and 2024, making it Kerala's largest constituency.

As expected, the BJP mounted a sharp counterattack to Rahul's charges and released a dossier alleging that constituencies won by key Opposition leaders in 2024 were themselves riddled with irregularities. It claims an audit of voter rolls in Rae Bareli, Wayanad, Diamond Harbour, Kannauj, Mainpuri and Kolathur—represented by Rahul, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, Abhishek Banerjee, Akhilesh Yadav, Dimple Yadav and M.K. Stalin respectively—found "massive discrepancies", including duplicate entries, fake addresses, fictitious relatives and bulk additions.

In Rae Bareli, the BJP lists over 200,000 "doubtful" voters: 19,512 duplicates, 71,977 with fake addresses, 15,853 from "mixed households" and 92,747 allegedly added en masse, some aged 85-92. In Diamond Harbour, it alleges 259,779 suspect names, including 3,613 duplicates, 155,000 with fake addresses and



RAISING QUESTIONS Rahul Gandhi during his press conference at the Congress headquarters in New Delhi, Aug. 7